BHARAT TO THE FORE

When it comes to scheme saturation, work continues apace, but the absence of an implementation model mars all good intentions

By Amarnath K. Menon



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THE INCREASING FOCUS ON rural development has Panchayati Raj institutions in the throes of change. The call for saturation of schemes in the panchayats is making steady progress, though the ministry, headed by Giriraj Singh, is yet to develop a model that helps implement them faster. However, the allocation under the Finance Commission—direct transfer to the panchayat—that was just Rs 54 per person two decades ago is now Rs 700.

Despite rapid urbanisation, the majority of India's population still lives in villages. Women are increasingly essaying a key role. Of the 315,000 elected representatives of rural local bodies, 46 per cent are women. As many as 21 states have reserved 50 per cent seats for women in three-tier panchayats—way beyond the 33 per cent constitutional provision.

About 310,000 elected representatives have been trained in how to make their villages sustainable under the Gram Swaraj Abhiyaan. The parameters for determining the vibrant panchayats have changed to include carbon neutrality, water sufficiency, literacy and employment generation. A positive outcome is the increasing competitiveness among panchayats with more than 90 per cent vying for national awards.

The Deendayal Antyodaya Yojana–National Rural Livelihoods Mission (DAY-NRLM), a flagship poverty alleviation programme of the Ministry of Rural Development, has its footprints in 6,861 blocks of 723 districts in the country (except Delhi and Chandigarh). It has mobilised 87.1 million women from poor and vulnerable communities into 8.1 million Self Help Groups.

The Pradhan Mantri Gram Sadak Yojana-III, launched in 2019, for consolidation of 1.25 lakh km through routes and major rural links connecting habitations to village agricultural markets, higher secondary schools and hospitals has gathered pace in implementation. A total of 162,373 habitations, more than 99 per cent of eligible habitations, have been provided connectivity since the scheme's inception.

BOLD & BRAVE

40 PER CENT
Share of women in 315,000 elected representatives of rural local bodies

2.5 LAKH
Villages drone-surveyed under SVAMITVA scheme for property ownership

6,861 BLOCKS
in 723 districts benefit from poverty alleviation programme Deendayal Antyodaya Yojana (Rural)

BUT...

MNREGA Allocation

↓ 33%

(Figures in Rs crore)



Despite the progress, hurdles remain in the way of successful rural development. The biggest being the lack of transparency in the system of administration. Corruption thrives. The accountability mismatch between special purpose vehicles, agencies and panchayats aggravates this. So, to foster efficient rural growth, the ministry is introducing measures to digitise rural space and promote local e-governance. That is vital to make our 650,000 villages and over 800 million citizens self-sufficient. ■